

THE CONGRESS LOYALIST

PATIL'S LINKS WITH THE GANDHI DYNASTY CONTINUE TO BE STRONG



FAMILY TIES: With Indira Gandhi, when she visited the Patil residence in 1980. She was close to Indira and tended to her kitchen when Sanjay died.



FLORAL SALUTE: With Rajiv Gandhi as deputy chairperson of the Rajya Sabha. Rajiv had made her the chief of the Maharashtra Congress.



HIGH COMMAND: With the Congress President. Sonia was the one who appointed her Governor and brought her back in mainstream politics.

MEMORIES IN SEPIA



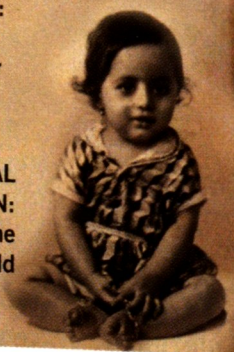
LEGAL EAGLE: With lawyers at an international seminar

MARATHA CONNECTION: With Sharad Pawar while she was president of MPCC



EARLY START: Soon after her political career kickstarted in 1962.

PRODIGAL POLITICIAN: Pratibha the child



case—to decide. But more serious is the charge, against her husband, of abetment to a suicide.

Kisan Dhage was a teacher who worked at the Shreemati Nathibai High School in Sungaon in the Buldana district run by Devisinh Shekhawat under the Vidya Bharati Pratishtan. Not paid salary, Dhage filed a case in the Nagpur Bench of the high court against the trust. The court ordered that Dhage be paid salary. The trust did not implement the order and Dhage, who was burdened with debt, committed suicide on November 15, 1998, and named Shekhawat as one of those responsible for it. After a struggle, when Dhage's family managed to get an FIR registered, Shekhawat sought anticipatory bail, which was rejected by both the lower court and the sessions court in Khamgaon, which stated that "these instances are sufficient enough to inspire that these accused had abetted Mr Kisan Dhage to commit suicide by creating an unbearable situation for his survival and also making him unable to maintain his family." It added that "prima facie there is sufficient grounds" to uphold the lower court's order in denying bail.

This was in February. Devisinh has recently got an interim stay in the high court asking for a review and Dhage's family has begun receiving pension after the court's order. Innocent till proved guilty may be the credo of the judicial system, but the high office of President calls for integrity and freedom from taint, however distant or light in hue. As BJP leader Sushma Swaraj asks, what if the CBI finds Devisinh guilty or chargesheets him? "Will they go to Rashtrapati Bhavan to arrest the *pati* of the *rashtrapati*?"

Though Sonia had asked her core team to get all the three women candidates scrutinised and all of them were given a clean chit, there has obviously been a slip-up. As the battle heats up, more dirt will be raised. To those in the know, the support from Shiv Sena on the Marathi *manoos* plank is no surprise. Patil's uncle Diwan Raobahadur was friends with Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray's family and his father Prabodhankar Thackeray, and she has maintained the friendship. Sena leader Sanjay Raut adds, "She has high